

“Out of Nature”: The Byzantine Golden Bird in Yeats’s

Sailing to Byzantium

As James L. Allen points out, the golden bird in W. B. Yeats’s *Sailing to Byzantium* is often understood as a symbol of spiritual immortality.¹ However, this interpretation raises an important question that remains unanswered: why does the speaker use a bird made of “hammered gold and gold enamelling” to symbolize immortality, rather than a living bird or a purely spiritual imagery? This essay delves into the historical prototype of the Byzantine golden bird, and argues why Yeats was inspired by such a decidedly unnatural image.

The Byzantine background of the imagery in Yeats’s poetry has a precise historical basis. Yeats himself wrote in a note that he had “read somewhere” of a tree made of gold and silver in the emperor’s palace at Byzantium, with artificial birds that sang.² Archibald A. Hill connects this statement with historical accounts of the palace of the emperor Theophilus, especially the famous mechanical wonders of the Magnaura. Hill describes a golden plane-tree shading the imperial throne, with golden birds perched on its branches. On audience days, when foreign ambassadors entered the hall, the birds “fluttered and sang”, while golden lions rose and gave “metallic roars”.³ Notopoulos also recalls Liutprand of Cremona’s account of the Byzantine court, where the rising throne, roaring lions, golden tree, and singing birds formed an “artistic and mechanical fairyland”.⁴

These historical accounts confirm that Yeats’s image had a real-world basis. Yet, the mere existence of a mechanical bird does not fully explain its profound appeal for the poet. Why does Yeats have a particular fondness for Byzantium? When the speaker in the poem faces ultimate concerns such as aging and death, Yeats chooses to have him sail to Byzantium, rather than to some other paradise.

¹ James L. Allen, Jr., “Yeats’s Bird-Soul Symbolism”, *Twentieth Century Literature* 6, no. 3 (1960): 117.

² W. B. Yeats, *The Collected Poems of W. B. Yeats* (New York: Macmillan, 1933), 450, quoted in Archibald A. Hill, “Method in Source Study: Yeats’ Golden Bird of Byzantium as a Test Case”, *Texas Studies in Literature and Language* 17, no. 2 (Summer 1975): 525.

³ Charles Diehl, “From Nicephorus I to the Fall of the Phrygian Dynasty”, in *The Cambridge Medieval History*, ed. J. B. Bury et al., vol. 4 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1923), 39–40, quoted in Hill, “Method in Source Study”, 527–28.

⁴ James A. Notopoulos, “Byzantine Platonism in Yeats”, *The Classical Journal* 54, no. 7 (April 1959): 319–20.

In fact, Yeats believed that ancient Byzantium represented a unique civilization: here, artifice could carry spiritual meaning, and sacred art and eternal form were unified into a single expressive order.⁵ In *A Vision*, Yeats imagined early Byzantium as a world where “religious, aesthetic, and practical life were one”, a culture in which goldsmiths, mosaic workers, and illuminators shared in a collective spiritual vision.⁶ And the mechanical golden bird properly belongs to this ideal civilization. Its artificiality actually aligns perfectly with Yeats’s spiritual ideal - an artificial creation becoming a visible shape of spiritual order.

Now let’s return to the poem *Sailing to Byzantium* and explore the special significance of the artificiality of the golden bird. The poem begins by depicting a vivid world, which is filled with young people, birds, and various lively creatures. However, Yeats immediately calls them “those dying generations”. James A. Notopoulos describes the stanza as an expression of “mortality” and “mutability”, where sensuous life already contains the signs of decay.⁷ The natural bird is singing now, but one day its song will die along with it. So the speaker’s problem is that although the natural world is not lacking in beauty, the natural beauty cannot escape time. The golden bird answers this need by offering a body that is deliberately artificial. “Once out of nature I shall never take / My bodily form from any natural thing.” The rejection is absolute: he refuses any future form derived from nature. Instead, he imagines a form “as Grecian goldsmiths make / Of hammered gold and gold enamelling”. Unlike the natural birds of the first stanza, it is not begotten, born, or dying. Therefore, its artificiality is exactly what makes it desirable.

Another question is, since the golden bird is artificial and mechanical, is it just a lifeless toy without any spiritual meaning? The answer should be no. The bird’s body is artificial, but its song gives it poetic and spiritual meaning. Holberg makes a distinction between the singer and the song.⁸ The golden bird may be a crafted object, even something close to an ornament in the emperor’s court, but what it sings is not meaningless. It sings “of what is past, or passing, or to come”. Its song is therefore connected with time, memory, change, and perhaps wisdom. In this sense, the golden bird is extremely valuable because it can keep singing after natural life has

⁵ “Sailing to Byzantium”, *Encyclopaedia Britannica*, accessed May 8, 2026, www.britannica.com/topic/Sailing-to-Byzantium.

⁶ W. B. Yeats, *A Vision*, quoted in Notopoulos, “Byzantine Platonism in Yeats”, 316.

⁷ James A. Notopoulos, “Byzantine Platonism in Yeats”, *The Classical Journal* 54, no. 7 (1959): 318-19.

⁸ Stanley M. Holberg, “‘Sailing to Byzantium’: A New Source and a New Reading”, *English Language Notes* 12, no. 2 (December 1974): 114–15.

passed away. Allen's account of Yeats's bird-soul symbolism also clarifies this issue. In Yeats's later work, bird song often becomes a medium for disembodied or posthumous existence; song allows the soul to appear after the ordinary human body has fallen away.⁹ In *Sailing to Byzantium*, the golden bird gives this old symbol a fresh meaning. The speaker seeks survival as a crafted voice. His ideal afterlife is poetic: the mortal body disappears, but the singing lasts forever.

Now we can return to the question posed at the beginning: why the Byzantine golden bird? Because only art can offer a meaningful escape from time. A natural bird, however beautiful, belongs to the realm of "those dying generations". But as a crafted object that sings, the Byzantine golden bird provides the speaker with a perfect form of immortality - a body that can carry eternal songs beyond decay. In Yeats's hands, the mechanical bird becomes the soul's golden instrument.

⁹ Allen, "Yeats's Bird-Soul Symbolism", 119–20.